

2004 NBA Finals

The **2004 NBA Finals** was the championship round of the National Basketball Association's (NBA) 2003–04 season, and the conclusion of the season's playoffs. This season's NBA Finals was contested between the Western Conference playoff champion Los Angeles Lakers and the Eastern Conference playoff champion Detroit Pistons. The Lakers held home court advantage, and the series was played under a best-of-seven format.

This was the third NBA Finals matchup in the history of the Lakers-Pistons rivalry. Although the Lakers, headed by Kobe Bryant and Shaquille O'Neal, were considered the heavy favorites,^[1] the underdog Pistons handily won the series in five games. The series is commonly referred to as a "five-game sweep" because Detroit dominated in each of their four wins while the Lakers barely managed to win Game 2 in overtime. This marked the Pistons' third NBA championship and their first since their back-to-back championships in 1989 and 1990. The series ultimately featured the perceived underdog Pistons^[1] dominating a Lakers team that included four future Hall of Famers. Pistons' owner William Davidson became the first owner in American sports history to win two championships in one calendar year; eight days earlier, his Tampa Bay Lightning defeated the Calgary Flames to win the NHL's Stanley Cup Finals in seven games.

As of 2026, this is the most recent major professional sports championship to be won by a Detroit-based team at their home venue.

Background

Los Angeles Lakers

The Lakers had won three consecutive championships from 2000 to 2002 but lost to the eventual champions, the San Antonio Spurs, in the Western Conference semifinals in 2003 to end their streak at three. The Spurs beat the Lakers in 6 games.^[2]

The Lakers were rocked by Kobe Bryant's arrest for sexual assault on July 18 for allegedly raping a 19-year old female hotel employee in Eagle, Colorado.^{[3][4]} The charges against Bryant were later dismissed in September, but the story was major talking point throughout the season. In the 2003 offseason, the Lakers made major changes with initially varying results. Needing to find a point guard and a power forward to defend against Tim Duncan and the Spurs, the Lakers signed veteran stars Gary Payton and Karl Malone for well below market value; they also hoped to give both veterans their first championship ring. The Lakers were afterwards considered the favorites to win the NBA title.^[5]

During the regular season, after starting the season 18–3, the Lakers were afflicted by numerous injuries, as well as the ongoing Kobe and Shaq feud, and stumbled to a 56–26 record to finish the season with the second seed in the Western Conference.^[2] Despite their feud, for the fourth straight season, Bryant and O'Neal made the First Team All-NBA.^[6]

The Lakers breezed past their first-round opponent, the Houston Rockets, headlining a matchup between Shaquille O'Neal and a young Yao Ming. They defeated the squad 4–1 but then lost the first two games in their series against the Spurs before a dramatic comeback on Derek Fisher's 0.4 shot in Game 5 that saw them win the game and the series, 4–2.^[7] They then faced the Minnesota Timberwolves and league MVP Kevin Garnett. The Lakers won the series 4–2 to advance to the Finals.^[8]

Detroit Pistons

The Pistons won two back-to-back championships in 1989 and 1990, but with retirements and departures of several stars, they faded from relevance.^[9] The team hired former star Joe Dumars as general manager of the team in 2000, and he began stockpiling draft picks and trading players. He landed defensive stalwart Ben Wallace and guard Richard Hamilton by trading established stars in controversial trades, signed Chauncey Billups who was considered an underachiever, and drafted Tayshaun Prince with the 23rd pick in the 2002 draft. He was named the NBA Executive of the Year in 2003 for returning the Pistons to prominence.^[10]

2004 NBA Finals



Team	Coach	Wins
Detroit Pistons	Larry Brown	4
Los Angeles Lakers	Phil Jackson	1

Dates	June 6–15
MVP	<u>Chauncey Billups</u> (Detroit Pistons)
Hall of Famers	Pistons: <u>Chauncey Billups</u> (2024) <u>Ben Wallace</u> (2021) Lakers: <u>Kobe Bryant</u> (2020) <u>Karl Malone</u> (2010) <u>Shaquille O'Neal</u> (2016) <u>Gary Payton</u> (2013) Coaches: <u>Larry Brown</u> (2002) <u>Phil Jackson</u> (2007) <u>Tex Winter</u> (2011) Officials: <u>Dick Bavetta</u> (2015) <u>Danny Crawford</u> (2025) <u>Joey Crawford</u> (2026)
Eastern finals	<u>Pistons</u> defeated <u>Pacers</u> , 4–2
Western finals	<u>Lakers</u> defeated <u>Timberwolves</u> , 4–2



Kobe Bryant excelled through a controversial season.

The Pistons made another major—perhaps, riskier—coaching change, firing head coach Rick Carlisle, who had led the Pistons to consecutive Central Division titles, 100 regular season wins, and had received the NBA Coach of the Year Award in 2002. In his place, Dumars hired legendary coach Larry Brown, who had most recently led the Philadelphia 76ers to the NBA Finals in 2001 against the Lakers.

In a three-team trade involving the Boston Celtics and Atlanta Hawks at the trade deadline, Dumars traded Chucky Atkins, Lindsey Hunter, Bobby Sura, Željko Rebrača, and other considerations for guard Mike James and forward Rasheed Wallace, who had been traded from the Portland Trail Blazers to the Hawks and then to the Pistons at the trade deadline.^[11] They proved to be the final pieces of the championship team. Lindsey Hunter would rejoin the Pistons a week later after being waived by the Celtics and be partnered with Mike James to create a formidable guard tandem off the bench dubbed "The Pit Bulls".^[12] They became the first team in NBA history to hold five consecutive opponents under 70 points, and finished the season with a 54–28 record and the third seed in the Eastern Conference.^[13]

The Pistons easily overcame the Milwaukee Bucks 4–1 but struggled against the defending conference champion New Jersey Nets. After splitting the first four games of the series, the Nets won Game 5 in Detroit in triple overtime to take a 3–2 series lead back to New Jersey. After falling behind by 12 early in Game 6, the Pistons stormed back in the second quarter and held on for an 81–75 victory to force a seventh game. The Pistons never trailed after the midway point of the first quarter and cruised to a 90–69 win to take the series.

In the Eastern Conference finals, a match up with the 61-win, Carlisle-led Indiana Pacers, the Pistons faltered in the final 90 seconds of Game 1, falling 78–74. In Game 2, Rasheed Wallace almost squandered a Detroit lead. With Detroit clinging to a 69–67 lead with under 30 seconds to play, Billups recovered the basketball after a Jermaine O'Neal blocked shot of Rasheed Wallace. Jamaal Tinsley stripped Billups and found Reggie Miller open down the court for what appeared to be the tying lay-up. As Miller approached the basket, Tayshaun Prince ran in from the left wing and blocked Miller's lay-up as it left his fingertips. Richard Hamilton recovered the loose ball before it went out of bounds and was fouled by Tinsley. Hamilton would make three free throws in the game's final 15 seconds to seal the victory 72–67 and tie the series. The Pistons rode the momentum of Game 2, including dominant wins in Games 3 and 5, to a 4–2 series victory, advancing to the NBA Finals for the first time in 14 years.^[14]

Road to the Finals

Los Angeles Lakers (Western Conference champion)						Detroit Pistons (Eastern Conference champion)					
#	Western Conference					#	Eastern Conference				
	Team	W	L	PCT	GB		Team	W	L	PCT	GB
1	c-Minnesota Timberwolves	58	24	.707	–	1	z-Indiana Pacers	61	21	.744	–
2	y-Los Angeles Lakers	56	26	.683	2	2	y-New Jersey Nets	47	35	.573	14
3	x-San Antonio Spurs	57	25	.695	1	3	x-Detroit Pistons	54	28	.659	7
4	x-Sacramento Kings	55	27	.671	3	4	x-Miami Heat	42	40	.512	19
5	x-Dallas Mavericks	52	30	.634	6	5	x-New Orleans Hornets	41	41	.500	20
6	x-Memphis Grizzlies	50	32	.610	8	6	x-Milwaukee Bucks	41	41	.500	20
7	x-Houston Rockets	45	37	.549	13	7	x-New York Knicks	39	43	.476	22
8	x-Denver Nuggets	43	39	.524	15	8	x-Boston Celtics	36	46	.439	25
9	e-Utah Jazz	42	40	.512	16	9	e-Cleveland Cavaliers	35	47	.427	26
10	e-Portland Trail Blazers	41	41	.500	17	10	e-Toronto Raptors	33	49	.402	28
11	e-Seattle SuperSonics	37	45	.451	21	11	e-Philadelphia 76ers	33	49	.402	28
12	e-Golden State Warriors	37	45	.451	21	12	e-Atlanta Hawks	28	54	.341	33
13	e-Phoenix Suns	29	53	.354	29	13	e-Washington Wizards	25	57	.305	36
14	e-Los Angeles Clippers	28	54	.341	30	14	e-Chicago Bulls	23	59	.280	38
2nd seed in the West, 4th best league record						3rd seed in the East, 6th best league record					
Defeated the (7) <u>Houston Rockets</u> , 4–1						First round	Defeated the (6) <u>Milwaukee Bucks</u> , 4–1				
Defeated the (3) <u>San Antonio Spurs</u> , 4–2						Conference semifinals	Defeated the (2) <u>New Jersey Nets</u> , 4–3				
Defeated the (1) <u>Minnesota Timberwolves</u> , 4–2						Conference finals	Defeated the (1) <u>Indiana Pacers</u> , 4–2				

Regular season series

The teams split the two meetings, each won by the home team:

November 14,
2003

Detroit Pistons 89, Los Angeles Lakers 94

Staples Center, Los Angeles,
California

November 18,
2003

Los Angeles Lakers 96, Detroit Pistons 106

The Palace of Auburn Hills, Auburn Hills, Michigan

Team rosters

Detroit Pistons

2003–04 Detroit Pistons roster								Coaches	
Players								Head coach	
Pos. ↕	No. ↕	Player ↕	Height ↕	Weight ↕	DOB ↕	From ↕			
<u>G</u>	1	<u>Chauncey Billups</u>	6 ft 3 in (1.91 m)	202 lb (92 kg)	1976–09–25	<u>Colorado</u>		▪ <u>Larry Brown</u>	
								Assistant(s)	
<u>C</u>	41	<u>Elden Campbell</u>	6 ft 11 in (2.11 m)	279 lb (127 kg)	1968–07–23	<u>Clemson</u>		▪ <u>Herb Brown</u>	
<u>F</u>	24	<u>Tremaine Fowlkes</u>	6 ft 7 in (2.01 m)	212 lb (96 kg)	1976–04–11	<u>Fresno State</u>		▪ <u>Dave Hanners</u>	
<u>F</u>	8	<u>Darvin Ham</u>	6 ft 7 in (2.01 m)	240 lb (109 kg)	1973–07–23	<u>Texas Tech</u>		▪ <u>Igor Kokoškov</u>	
								▪ <u>John Kuester</u>	
								▪ <u>Mike Woodson</u>	
<u>G/F</u>	32	<u>Richard Hamilton</u>	6 ft 7 in (2.01 m)	193 lb (88 kg)	1978–02–14	<u>Connecticut</u>		Legend	
<u>G</u>	10	<u>Lindsey Hunter</u>	6 ft 2 in (1.88 m)	195 lb (88 kg)	1970–12–03	<u>Jackson State</u>		▪ (DP) Unsigned draft pick	
<u>G</u>	7	<u>Mike James</u>	6 ft 2 in (1.88 m)	188 lb (85 kg)	1975–06–23	<u>Duquesne</u>		▪ (FA) Free agent	
<u>C</u>	31	<u>Darko Miličić</u>	7 ft 0 in (2.13 m)	275 lb (125 kg)	1985–06–20	<u>Serbia and Montenegro</u>		▪ (S) Suspended	
								▪ + Injured	
<u>F/C</u>	13	<u>Mehmet Okur</u>	6 ft 11 in (2.11 m)	290 lb (132 kg)	1979–05–26	<u>Turkey</u>		<u>Roster</u> (https://www.basketball-reference.com/teams/DET/2004.html)	
<u>F</u>	22	<u>Tayshaun Prince</u>	6 ft 9 in (2.06 m)	215 lb (98 kg)	1980–02–28	<u>Kentucky</u>		Updated: February 26, 2004	
<u>F/C</u>	3	<u>Ben Wallace</u>	6 ft 9 in (2.06 m)	245 lb (111 kg)	1974–09–10	<u>Virginia Union</u>			
<u>F/C</u>	30	<u>Rasheed Wallace</u>	6 ft 11 in (2.11 m)	230 lb (104 kg)	1974–09–17	<u>North Carolina</u>			
<u>F</u>	34	<u>Corliss Williamson</u>	6 ft 7 in (2.01 m)	245 lb (111 kg)	1973–12–04	<u>Arkansas</u>			

Los Angeles Lakers

2003–04 Los Angeles Lakers roster								Coaches	
Players								Head coach	
Pos. ↕	No. ↕	Player ↕	Height ↕	Weight ↕	DOB ↕	From ↕			
<u>G</u>	8	<u>Kobe Bryant</u>	6 ft 6 in (1.98 m)	205 lb (93 kg)	1978–08–23	<u>Lower Merion HS (PA)</u>		▪ <u>Phil Jackson</u>	
								Assistant(s)	
<u>F</u>	7	<u>Brian Cook</u>	6 ft 9 in (2.06 m)	234 lb (106 kg)	1980–12–04	<u>Illinois</u>		▪ <u>Jim Cleamons</u>	
<u>G</u>	2	<u>Derek Fisher</u>	6 ft 1 in (1.85 m)	210 lb (95 kg)	1974–08–09	<u>Little Rock</u>		▪ <u>Frank Hamblen</u>	
<u>F</u>	17	<u>Rick Fox</u>	6 ft 7 in (2.01 m)	230 lb (104 kg)	1969–07–24	<u>North Carolina</u>		▪ <u>Kurt Rambis</u>	
								▪ <u>Tex Winter</u>	
<u>F</u>	3	<u>Devean George</u>	6 ft 8 in (2.03 m)	235 lb (107 kg)	1977–08–29	<u>Augsburg</u>		Legend	
<u>F/C</u>	54	<u>Horace Grant</u>	6 ft 10 in (2.08 m)	245 lb (111 kg)	1965–07–04	<u>Clemson</u>		▪ (DP) Unsigned draft pick	
<u>F</u>	11	<u>Karl Malone</u>	6 ft 9 in (2.06 m)	250 lb (113 kg)	1963–07–24	<u>Louisiana Tech</u>		▪ (FA) Free agent	
								▪ (S) Suspended	
<u>F</u>	14	<u>Slava Medvedenko</u>	6 ft 10 in (2.08 m)	253 lb (115 kg)	1979–04–04	<u>Ukraine</u>		▪ + Injured	
<u>C</u>	34	<u>Shaquille O'Neal</u>	7 ft 1 in (2.16 m)	325 lb (147 kg)	1972–03–06	<u>LSU</u>		<u>Roster</u> (https://www.basketball-reference.com/teams/LAL/2004.html)	
<u>G</u>	20	<u>Gary Payton</u>	6 ft 4 in (1.93 m)	180 lb (82 kg)	1968–07–23	<u>Oregon State</u>		Updated: February 19, 2004	
<u>G</u>	21	<u>Kareem Rush</u>	6 ft 5 in (1.96 m)	200 lb (91 kg)	1980–10–30	<u>Missouri</u>			
<u>F</u>	9	<u>Bryon Russell</u>	6 ft 7 in (2.01 m)	225 lb (102 kg)	1970–12–31	<u>Long Beach State</u>			

Recap (https://web.archive.org/web/20100327113581/http://www.nba.com/games/20040606/DETAL/reCAP.html) at the Wayback Machine (archived March 21, 2010)	Detroit Pistons 87, Los Angeles Lakers 75 Scoring by quarter: 22–19, 18–22, 24–17, 23–17 Pts: Chauncey Billups 22 Pts: Shaquille O'Neal 34 Rebs: B. Wallace, R. Wallace 8 each Rebs: Malone, O'Neal 11 each Asts: Richard Hamilton 5 Asts: Kobe Bryant 4 <i>Detroit leads series, 1–0</i>	Staples Center, Los Angeles, California Attendance: 18,997 Referees: - No. 17 Joe Crawford - No. 26 Bob Delaney - No. 7 Bernie Fryer
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Considered to be a stunning upset by most of the NBA world, the Detroit Pistons managed to defeat the Lakers with imposing defense.^[19] Defensively clamping down on everyone but Bryant and O'Neal, the Pistons managed to hold everyone else to a total of 16 points. O'Neal recorded 34 points and 11 rebounds for the Lakers.

The Pistons trailed the Lakers 41–40 at halftime, but by the fourth quarter the Pistons had opened up a 13-point lead; they would not trail for the rest of the game. The Pistons outscored the Lakers 47 to 34 in the 2nd half as they got the road win in Los Angeles.^[20] Chauncey Billups recorded 22 points, 4 assists, and 3 steals to fuel his team towards the win.

Game 2

June 8 9:00 pm (6:00 pm PDT)	Recap (https://web.archive.org/web/20100327113582/http://www.nba.com/games/20040608/DETAL/reCAP.html) at the Wayback Machine (archived March 21, 2010)	Detroit Pistons 91, Los Angeles Lakers 99 (OT) Scoring by quarter: 16–18, 20–26, 30–24, 23–21, Overtime: 2–10 Pts: Chauncey Billups 27 Pts: Kobe Bryant 33 Rebs: Ben Wallace 14 Rebs: Karl Malone 9 Asts: Chauncey Billups 9 Asts: Luke Walton 8 <i>Series tied, 1–1</i>	Staples Center, Los Angeles, California Attendance: 18,997 Referees: - No. 15 Bennett Salvatore - No. 14 Joe DeRosa - No. 29 Steve Javie	ABC
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In Game 2, the Lakers had an 7-point lead at halftime, 43–36. However, in the third quarter, the Pistons scored 30 points, cutting the deficit to 68–66. Detroit took the lead on a Lindsey Hunter three-pointer, 71–68. However, the Lakers went on a 7–0 run to regain the lead with 7:00 remaining in the fourth quarter. With 47 seconds remaining, Ben Wallace made a putback to give the Pistons a 6-point advantage. The next play, Kobe Bryant missed a 3-pointer but O'Neal was there to grab the offensive board and made an and-1 to cut the deficit to 3. The Pistons led by three points with 10.9 seconds remaining in the final period. Coach Brown wanted to foul a Lakers player where they could get only 2 points rather than 3. However, the Pistons' veterans only wanted to intentionally foul O'Neal. Kobe Bryant's 3-point shot with 2.1 seconds left in the fourth quarter would force overtime, where the Pistons would make only one two-point field goal (compared to Los Angeles scoring ten points).^[21] Afterwards, on the team bus back to the airport, Billups told the Pistons' players and coaches, "We're not coming back to L.A."^[22]

Game 3

June 10 9:00 pm	Recap (https://web.archive.org/web/20100327113595/http://www.nba.com/games/20040610/LALDET/reCAP.html) at the Wayback Machine (archived	Los Angeles Lakers 68, Detroit Pistons 88 Scoring by quarter: 16–24, 16–15, 19–24, 17–25 Pts: Shaquille O'Neal 14 Pts: Richard Hamilton 31 Rebs: Medvedenko, O'Neal 8 each Rebs: Ben Wallace 11 Asts: Gary Payton 7 Asts: Billups, Hamilton, B. Wallace 3 each <i>Detroit leads series, 2–1</i>	The Palace of Auburn Hills, Auburn Hills, Michigan Referees: - No. 10 Ron Garretson - No. 43 Dan Crawford - No. 24 Mike Callahan	ABC
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March 21, 2010)

In Game 3, the Pistons were on fire to start. They started the game on a 10–2 run. At halftime, the Pistons led by seven, 39–32. The Pistons beat Los Angeles by 20 in their first NBA Finals appearance together at The Palace of Auburn Hills since 1989 to take a 2–1 lead in the series. The 68 points scored by the Lakers set a franchise record for the lowest number of points scored in a playoff game. Tayshaun Prince and the Pistons' defense were able to hold Kobe Bryant to 11 points on 4/13 (.308%) shooting, with Bryant going scoreless in the first half.^[23]

Game 4

June 13 9:00 pm	Recap (https://web.archive.org/web/20100321135930/http://www.nba.com/games/20040613/LALDET/recap.html) at the Wayback Machine (archived March 21, 2010)	Los Angeles Lakers 80, Detroit Pistons 88 Scoring by quarter: 22–21, 17–20, 17–15, 24–32 Pts: Shaquille O'Neal 36 Rebs: Shaquille O'Neal 20 Asts: Rick Fox 6 Pts: Rasheed Wallace 26 Rebs: B. Wallace, R. Wallace 13 each Asts: Richard Hamilton 6 Detroit leads series, 3–1	The Palace of Auburn Hills, Auburn Hills, Michigan ABC Referees: - No. 35 Jack Nies - No. 27 Dick Bavetta - No. 32 Eddie F. Rush
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Again, the Pistons defeated the Lakers, although this time by eight, to take a 3–1 series advantage.

O'Neal scored 36 for the Lakers and Bryant scored 20 but shot 32 percent from the field.^[24]

Karl Malone would play his last game, as a knee injury would not allow him to dress in Game 5.^[25]

Game 5

June 15 9:00 pm	Recap (https://web.archive.org/web/20100321135536/http://www.nba.com/games/20040615/LALDET/recap.html) at the Wayback Machine (archived March 21, 2010)	Los Angeles Lakers 87, Detroit Pistons 100 Scoring by quarter: 24–25, 21–30, 14–27, 28–18 Pts: Kobe Bryant 24 Rebs: Shaquille O'Neal 8 Asts: Luke Walton 5 Pts: Richard Hamilton 21 Rebs: Ben Wallace 22 Asts: Chauncey Billups 6 Detroit wins NBA Finals, 4–1	The Palace of Auburn Hills, Auburn Hills, Michigan ABC Referees: - No. 17 Joe Crawford - No. 7 Bernie Fryer - No. 15 Bennett Salvatore
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In Game 5, the Pistons won their first championship since 1990, and Larry Brown finally won a professional title. The Pistons defense had overcome the high-scoring Laker offense, winning the game by 13, winning the series 4–1, and also ending a long Laker dynasty that lasted for many years. The Pistons' 100 points was the first (and only) time either team scored triple digits in the series. The game saw the end of Phil Jackson's first run as the coach^[26]—he returned in the 2005–06 season^[27]—and saw O'Neal, Payton, and Malone's last games in Laker uniforms.^[28]

The series was also Karl Malone's last NBA Finals appearance. He holds an NBA record for having played the most playoff games without winning a championship (193).^[29]

Player statistics

Legend					
GP	Games played	GS	Games started	MPG	Minutes per game
FG%	Field-goal percentage	3P%	3-point field-goal percentage	FT%	Free-throw percentage
RPG	Rebounds per game	APG	Assists per game	SPG	Steals per game
BPG	Blocks per game	PPG	Points per game		

Detroit Pistons

Detroit Pistons statistics											
Player	GP	GS	MPG	FG%	3P%	FT%	RPG	APG	SPG	BPG	PPG
Chauncey Billups	5	5	38.4	.509	.471	.929	3.2	5.2	1.2	0.0	21.0
Elden Campbell	5	0	13.6	.375	.000	.500	2.6	1.6	1.0	0.6	3.4
Darvin Ham	4	0	2.5	1.000	.000	.000	0.3	0.0	0.0	0.0	0.5
Richard Hamilton	5	5	44.4	.402	.400	.853	5.2	4.0	0.8	0.0	21.4
Lindsey Hunter	5	0	13.0	.294	.250	1.000	1.4	0.8	0.6	0.4	3.6
Mike James	5	0	4.4	.500	.000	.000	0.8	0.8	0.0	0.0	0.8
Darko Miličić	3	0	1.7	.000	.000	.000	0.7	0.0	0.3	0.0	0.0
Mehmet Okur	4	0	9.8	.444	1.000	.500	1.5	0.5	0.0	0.0	2.8
Tayshaun Prince	5	5	39.2	.389	.188	.455	6.8	2.0	1.8	0.4	10.0
Ben Wallace	5	5	40.6	.478	.000	.294	13.6	1.4	1.8	1.0	10.8
Rasheed Wallace	5	5	30.2	.453	.250	.778	7.8	1.4	0.4	1.6	13.0
Corliss Williamson	5	0	10.4	.400	.000	.900	2.4	0.2	0.0	0.0	4.2

Los Angeles Lakers

Los Angeles Lakers statistics											
Player	GP	GS	MPG	FG%	3P%	FT%	RPG	APG	SPG	BPG	PPG
Kobe Bryant	5	5	46.2	.381	.174	.920	2.8	4.4	1.8	0.6	22.6
Brian Cook	3	0	7.0	.167	.000	1.000	2.7	0.0	0.3	0.0	1.3
Derek Fisher	5	0	20.2	.306	.375	.571	3.0	1.8	1.0	0.0	6.4
Rick Fox	3	0	10.0	.571	.000	.000	1.0	2.3	0.0	0.0	2.7
Devean George	5	5	20.8	.393	.333	0.5	2.8	0.6	1.0	0.4	5.8
Karl Malone	4	4	30.5	.333	.000	.667	7.3	2.3	0.3	0.3	5.0
Slava Medvedenko	5	1	14.4	.353	.000	.750	3.6	0.6	0.0	0.2	3.6
Shaquille O'Neal	5	5	42.6	.631	.000	.491	10.8	1.6	0.4	0.6	26.6
Gary Payton	5	5	33.6	.321	.200	.500	3.0	4.4	1.2	0.4	4.2
Kareem Rush	5	0	15.6	.318	.250	.000	1.0	0.4	0.2	0.0	3.6
Bryon Russell	3	0	2.7	.000	.000	.000	0.3	0.0	0.0	0.0	0.0
Luke Walton	4	0	19.3	.385	.167	1.000	3.0	4.5	1.5	0.5	3.3

Broadcast notes

The games were broadcast on ABC by [Al Michaels](#) and [Doc Rivers](#). This was the first of two NBA Finals assignments for Michaels, better known as the voice of *Monday Night Football* at the time, while Rivers departed the booth after the series to become head coach of the Boston Celtics. Rivers was replaced by [Hubie Brown](#) the following season. Rivers would not return to the broadcast booth until 2023, where he and [Doris Burke](#) replaced [Mark Jackson](#) and [Jeff Van Gundy](#) on the lead broadcast team alongside [Mike Breen](#); Jackson and Van Gundy were laid off by the network after the [2023 NBA Finals](#). However, Rivers' second stint in the booth only lasted until January 2024 when the [Milwaukee Bucks](#) hired him as head coach.

[Brent Musburger](#) and [Jack Ramsay](#) broadcast the Finals nationally on ESPN Radio. The finals were shown on [Sky Sports](#) in the United Kingdom and Ireland. In Canada, [Leafs TV](#) and RDS (in French) simulcast ABC, and [Azteca 13](#) broadcast the Finals in [Mexico](#). The local ABC stations for the competing cities were [WXYZ-TV](#) in Detroit and [KABC-TV](#) in Los Angeles.

To promote the series, the NBA used [The Black Eyed Peas](#)' song "[Let's Get It Started](#)", which it had also used throughout the [2004 NBA playoffs](#).^[30]

Aftermath

The Pistons won 54 games the following season, earning the second seed in the Eastern Conference. They returned to the NBA Finals, where they lost to the San Antonio Spurs in seven games. The Pistons would continue their run of Eastern Conference superiority in the ensuing three years; losing in the Conference finals each time. After a particularly painful loss to the eventual champion [Boston Celtics](#) in the [2007–08 season](#), management would finally break up the core of the team and enter a period of losing seasons.

The Lakers' collapse became apparent in the days following the Finals. Head coach Phil Jackson abruptly resigned, Shaquille O'Neal was traded to the Miami Heat, where he eventually won a championship in 2006; Gary Payton was dealt to the Celtics, and Karl Malone was left unsigned, which subsequently resulted in Malone's retirement following the start of 2004–05 NBA season. Players from the three-peat era that left the team were Rick Fox, who retired, and Derek Fisher, who signed a lucrative free-agent contract with the Golden State Warriors.^{[31][32]} The 2004–05 season was a tough one for the Lakers as they won just 34 games and missed the playoffs. Jackson returned to the Lakers in the following offseason; despite penning a book dubiously entitled: *The Last Season: A Team in Search of Its Soul*, in which he voiced disdain for Kobe Bryant; calling him 'uncoachable'. Jackson and Bryant would quickly bury the hatchet once the season began; the duo, in the ensuing years would appear in three more NBA Finals in 2008, 2009, and 2010, winning the latter two.

This was the third "Big Four" postseason series in five years involving teams from Detroit and Los Angeles, as the Detroit Red Wings and Los Angeles Kings of the National Hockey League previously faced off in the 2000 and 2001 Stanley Cup playoffs. The next postseason matchup involving both cities would not come until the 2023 NFC Wild Card Round between the Detroit Lions and the Los Angeles Rams of the National Football League.

With the Detroit Shock previously defeating the Los Angeles Sparks to win the 2003 WNBA Finals, this marked the second time a city concurrently held the WNBA and NBA championships within a fiscal year, after the Sparks in 2001 and 2002 followed the Lakers' NBA title wins. It also marked the only occurrence in which the same two cities faced each other in both the WNBA and NBA Finals within the same period.



Ben Wallace and the Pistons with President George W. Bush

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